

Interview Transcripts

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The following transcripts have been lightly edited for clarity, not for brevity. Filler words and asides are retained where they show how people actually speak. Speaker names are shown in bold. The interviewer is a member of the engagement team. Cite conversations by reference code, for example (ST-01).

ST-01 - Hung Vo, Programmes Director

Interviewer: Thank you for making time. To start broadly - what is keeping you up at night right now?

Hung: Honestly? We are succeeding ourselves into a crisis. That sounds dramatic, but I mean it. There are 1,100 young people on the waitlist. Families call the hubs in tears. Mothers sit in the reception at Dong Nai and will not leave until someone gives them a date. And at the same time my field team is working sixty-hour weeks because the Board will not let us hire until there is a 'strategy'. So every week the queue grows and the people already inside the programmes get less attention.

Interviewer: When you say the Board will not let you hire - is that a formal freeze?

Hung: It is a practical freeze. Anh Duc says we should wait for the VPBank decision before we add headcount, in case we need to restructure. I understand the logic on paper. In the field it means Minh and his colleagues are carrying caseloads that would get a social worker fired in any proper system. We are choosing growth talk over care, and I am tired of pretending that is strategy.

Interviewer: Tell me more about Dong Nai specifically.

Hung: Transport, first. The young people commute a long way to the industrial zones - twenty-five, sometimes forty kilometres - and they pay 150 to 200 thousand dong a month for buses that we do not cover. If the family is already stretched, that is the difference between staying and quitting. Internship drop-out hit 38 per cent last quarter against about 22 for the organisation. Second, employers. Some of our 'partners' treat interns as free labour. Long hours, no learning plan, no contract conversation. I have names. I have reported them. Progress is slow because Development worries about the relationship.

Interviewer: You mentioned a reporting disagreement with Anh Duc?

Hung: Yes. He wanted us to report 'completion' for Dong Nai using a softer denominator - basically anyone who finished classroom training, not internship completion. It would have made the numbers look less ugly. I refused. If we start that game with ourselves, we will eventually play it with VPBank, and then we deserve whatever happens.

Interviewer: Should GBF expand to Long An?

Hung: Not until Dong Nai works. The Long An pilot lost about 60 per cent of its young people. Same pattern - distance, thin staffing, employers we barely know. There is a board member pushing Long An hard. I will not name him on the record, but his arguments sound more like political contacts than programme design. If we open another broken hub to please a Board faction, we will burn the VPBank money and the young people at the same time.

Interviewer: And Pathway Digital - where do you stand?

Hung: It is cheaper per head, yes. On a spreadsheet it looks like the answer to scale. But the real completion rate is about 52 per cent, not the 68 we put in front of the donor. The digital team counted enrolments, not people who actually finished. I have asked them to correct it before it becomes a reputational problem. Also - and this matters - many of our young people do not have a laptop. Digital is not a neutral substitute for Skills Forward; it selects for those who already have more.

Interviewer: If you could get one concrete thing from this consulting review, what would it be?

Hung: Permission - Board permission - to pause geographic expansion and fix quality for twelve months. Even if a couple of bad employers complain. Even if Anh Duc says we are 'losing momentum'. Momentum toward what? A larger waitlist and the same broken Dong Nai story, just with a bigger grant attached.

ST-02 - Thao Le, Operations Director

Interviewer: We keep hearing different placement rates. Is the 71 per cent in the annual report accurate?

Thao: It depends what you mean by placed - and that is exactly the problem. If you include gig work at fifteen hours a week or more, then yes, on the public definition in D-01, you can get to around 71 for that reporting year. If you mean a formal labour contract with social insurance, it is closer to 63 per cent. VPBank knows we use the broader definition in the agreement language, but they have also asked, quietly, for formal to be shown separately. Anyone who quotes one number without saying which definition is either careless or selling something.

Interviewer: What about the export Workflow B will see - should they expect 71?

Thao: No. The operational export is a different cut of time and a messier file. Tell them to define Completed versus Dropped, Formal versus Gig, and blank follow-ups before they celebrate or panic. I would rather a honest 65 with a footnote than a pretty 71 that collapses under audit.

Interviewer: What does it actually cost to serve one young person?

Thao: Skills Forward is about 12.8 million dong per completer when you include staff time, not just the classroom budget. Pathway Digital is about 6.2 million, but its placement rate is lower and the completion story is softer, as Hung will tell you. People love the unit-cost comparison until you ask what quality you bought.

Interviewer: Can GBF realistically reach 4,000 young people by 2028?

Thao: Only with the VPBank money and roughly twenty-five more staff - and that is optimistic. Recruitment is hard. We lose people to factory HR jobs and to YouthWorks, which pays less prestige but sometimes more certainty. Turnover was 34 per cent last year. You cannot scale a people-intensive model on a slide deck. You scale it with hiring pipelines, mentor benches, and supervisors who are not already drowning.

Interviewer: The Executive Director has talked about an intake chatbot. Your view?

Thao: I think it is a distraction dressed as innovation. Our young people need a human voice on the phone - someone who can hear that the mother is crying, that the bus money is gone, that the accent is from the Delta. A chatbot that cannot parse that will just move the queue from WhatsApp into a CRM and call it efficiency. Fix Dong Nai transport before you buy software theatre.

Interviewer: Anything else the team should pressure-test in the data?

Thao: Capacity. Look at hub burn rates and caseloads, not only placement. A scenario that clears a funding gap but breaks staff is not a scenario - it is a future resignation letter.

ST-03 - Linh Nguyen, Monitoring & Evaluation Officer

Interviewer: How reliable is GBF's data, in your honest view?

Linh: Frankly, it is a mess - and I say that as the person who lives in it. We have duplicate beneficiary IDs with conflicting fields, dates in three different formats, and field staff who

sometimes mark someone as placed after a single ride-hailing shift because the young person sounded hopeful on the phone. There are four of us covering about 800 young people in the current served population. We are not lazy; we are underbuilt. The public reports look clean because someone sanded them.

Interviewer: If our analysts open the export, what should they check first?

Linh: Duplicates - de-duplicate carefully, and use `last_updated` if it is there. Normalise `placed_90d` before you count anything; blank is not the same as not placed. Look at Dong Nai costs for the third quarter - I think a month was entered twice. And there is at least one wage figure that is obviously a typo; it should be flagged in the notes. Also watch province labels: HCMC versus Ho Chi Minh City. People double-count that if they are not careful.

Interviewer: What about young people with disabilities?

Linh: We report about six to seven per cent of beneficiaries with a disability flag. The population share among the young people we should be reaching is nearer nine. Their placement rate is about 45 to 50 per cent against roughly 70 on the public broad definition. Donors almost never see that breakdown, and when they do not ask, Development does not volunteer it. That is not a data problem only - it is a courage problem.

Interviewer: Any last warning for the consulting team?

Linh: Do not trust a single rate. Ask for the definition, the denominator, the missingness, and who benefits if the number is high. If they cannot answer those four, they do not understand the number yet. And watch for pressure to make the picture look good earlier than the data can honestly support - that temptation never arrives wearing a villain costume.

ST-04 - Anh Duc Pham, Development Director

Interviewer: How serious is the YouthWorks threat, from your side of the house?

Anh Duc: Overstated, in my view. They have speed and a free offer, but they have no real internship pathway. Our outcomes are better when young people stay the course. Yes, they are faster and we take longer - that is the trade. Young people who want a real job with insurance still come to us. The panic I hear from the field is real emotionally, but it is not a strategy case for abandoning our model.

Interviewer: And the VPBank offer?

Anh Duc: It is the opportunity of a decade. Eight billion dong over three years if we hit 65 per cent and show a credible path to 4,000 young people by 2028. We should commit publicly. Hesitation kills donor confidence. Other organisations are already whispering that GBF is 'quality-obsessed and growth-shy'. That narrative sticks.

Interviewer: Hung and others want to pause expansion and fix quality first. How do you hear that?

Anh Duc: I hear fear dressed as principle. Of course Dong Nai needs attention. Of course we should not invent numbers. But 'pause' without a growth path is how foundations quietly move money elsewhere. Bring me a plan that fixes quality and still scales. Do not bring me a sermon about integrity that ends with a smaller organisation and a disappointed Board.

Interviewer: How should the Board think about measuring success under the grant?

Anh Duc: Practically. Donors and Boards need visibility before every story is fully baked. If we only talk outcomes when every file is perfect, we will always arrive late to the conversation. I want management dashboards that show momentum earlier - leading indicators, pipeline, early placement signals - so we can manage, not only audit. M&E sometimes treats that as heresy. I treat it as running an organisation. I am not asking anyone to invent results. I am asking us not to wait for perfect purity while competitors take the room.

Interviewer: What would make you change your mind about aggressive scale?

Anh Duc: Hard evidence that we cannot hit 65 honestly under growth - not anecdotes, not one bad hub treated as destiny. If the data team shows that Aggressive growth forces selection bias

or burns staff past recovery, I will listen. Until then, I will keep pushing for ambition. Someone has to.

ST-05 - Minh Tran, Field Officer, Dong Nai

Interviewer: Describe your caseload as it actually feels day to day.

Minh: There are four of us at the Dong Nai hub for roughly two hundred young people across the year - active cases sit closer to 120 at any one time, but the policy caseload target is about forty per officer and we are regularly over fifty. On paper we visit every employer monthly. That is simply not possible. Some weeks I choose between a crisis home visit and an employer check. Guess which one loses.

Interviewer: You mentioned employer problems - can you be specific?

Minh: Two employers on our partner list exploit the interns - ten-hour days, no real learning duties, 'be grateful you are here' when someone asks for a contract. I reported them months ago with names and dates. Nothing meaningful happened. Development worries about losing the partner. I worry about losing the young person. Those worries are not equal.

Interviewer: How does transport show up in your conversations?

Minh: Every week. A young person will say, quietly, that the bus is 180 thousand that month and their mother needs medicine. Then they stop coming. We call it drop-out. It is often arithmetic. We modelled quietly - just the field team - that a transport stipend of about 100 thousand dong a month would roughly halve our internship drop-out. Nobody has budgeted it because expansion stories are sexier.

Interviewer: Is YouthWorks affecting your waitlist?

Minh: Last month they took about fifteen young people off our waitlist in the border districts. Families do not care about our theory of change when someone offers a free course next Tuesday. I do not blame them. I blame us for making them wait seven months while we argue about Board strategy in Ho Chi Minh City.

Interviewer: What should the consultants not get wrong about Dong Nai?

Minh: Do not treat us as a 'underperforming hub' on a dashboard and then recommend more volume. We are underperforming because the model is under-resourced and some employers are bad actors. Fix those, then talk about scale. Also - please talk to the young people who left, not only the ones who finished and smiled for the donor photo.

BN-01 - Mai, Programme graduate, Ho Chi Minh City

Interviewer: Mai, thank you for meeting us. Can you walk me through how you found GBF and what the waiting was like?

Mai: I heard about Skills Forward from a neighbour whose son did it the year before. I applied and then I waited. Five months. At month three I almost gave up - I was helping at a small coffee place and the owner said he might train me himself. My mother said wait for GBF because of the insurance. So I waited. When the call finally came I cried on the bus home. It sounds silly, but the waiting is part of the story. People talk about the training. They forget the months of nothing.

Interviewer: What was the training like once you started?

Mai: Good, mostly. I learned Excel properly, customer service, how to write a CV that does not sound like a child wrote it. The teachers were patient. The group helped each other. I liked that. It felt like someone was finally taking us seriously as workers, not as charity cases.

Interviewer: And the internship?

Mai: That was harder. It was far from home - about 170 thousand dong a month in bus fares that I paid myself. Some days I skipped lunch to make the money stretch. But the company was decent. They explained the work. They did not shout. After the internship they offered me a real contract, 5.8 million dong a month, with social insurance. I was lucky. I know I was lucky.

Interviewer: Lucky compared to whom?

Mai: My friend in the Dong Nai group. She quit because the employer made them work ten-hour days for nothing useful - just sorting boxes and being told to smile. She said GBF never came to check. When I told my caseworker, they sighed like they had heard it before. That sigh stayed with me.

Interviewer: Would Pathway Digital have suited you instead?

Mai: No. I do not have a laptop and my phone is old. The screen cracks and Zoom freezes. Skills Forward was right for me because I needed a place to go and people to practise with. Online sounds modern. For me it would have been lonely and impossible.

Interviewer: If GBF asked what to fix first, what would you say?

Mai: Help with transport during internship. And check the employers. A certificate means nothing if the workplace teaches you that you do not matter.

BN-02 - Tuan, Withdrew from the programme, Dong Nai

Interviewer: Tuan, we know this might be uncomfortable. Can you tell us why you left the programme?

Tuan: The training was fine - I am not angry about the classroom. The internship was miserable. No contract conversation, ten-hour days, and the boss told us to be grateful we were even there. Grateful for what? Free work? My mother is ill. I help at her coffee stall when I can. I could not keep paying for buses and losing hours at the stall while a man shouted that I should smile more. So I left. GBF called it drop-out. I call it choosing my mother over a bad placement.

Interviewer: Did anyone from GBF visit the workplace before or during?

Tuan: At the start, maybe once, briefly. After that, no. When I complained to my caseworker he said he would 'note it'. Nothing changed. People in meetings talk about numbers. Nobody asked me what the bus cost or what the boss said when I asked about insurance. I still want a factory job with proper social insurance. I did not leave because I am lazy. I left because the internship was not a pathway; it was a discount worker scheme with a GBF logo on it.

Interviewer: What would have kept you in?

Tuan: Employers who respect us. A real check from GBF that is not just a photo for Facebook. And some help with transport - even 100 thousand a month would have changed the calculation. Also honesty. If the placement is bad, say it is bad. Do not tell us we are lucky while we are being used.

Interviewer: Have you looked at YouthWorks since?

Tuan: I went to one information session. It was short and free. No internship. I did not join yet. I am waiting to see if GBF cleans up. My mother still asks when I will have insurance. I do not know what to tell her.

Interviewer: Anything you want the Board to hear, in your words?

Tuan: Stop counting me as a failure metric and start counting the bus fare and the bad bosses. If you expand before you fix that, you will just create more people like me - quiet, gone, and still needing work.

BN-03 - Lan, Graduate with a disability, Ho Chi Minh City

Interviewer: Lan, was the programme accessible for you in practice?

Lan: At first, no. The building had no ramp. I had to be carried up two steps by classmates, which is humiliating even when people are kind. After I complained - and I had to complain more than once - they moved the class downstairs. That should not have required a campaign. My mentor was kind, genuinely, but she did not know much about disability employment rights. She kept saying 'stay positive'. Positivity does not install a ramp or change an employer's mind.

Interviewer: How has the job search gone since you finished?

Lan: Still looking after four months. Interviews where they smile and say they will call, and then

silence. One HR person asked, in front of others, whether I would 'slow the team down'. GBF counts me as 'in progress' on their list. I understand why they need categories. Still, it feels like I am a statistic with a polite label, not a person they are fighting for.

Interviewer: Did the programme talk about disability and work openly?

Lan: Very little. Soft skills, CV, interview practice - useful, but generic. Nobody role-played how to answer a discriminatory question. Nobody connected me to employers who already hire people with disabilities. Mentoring helped emotionally. It did not open doors.

Interviewer: What would good support look like?

Lan: Access sorted before day one, not after a complaint. Mentors trained on rights, not only encouragement. Employers screened for accessibility, the same way you should screen for exploitation. And stop hiding our placement rate inside the overall number. If it is lower - and Linh says it is - say so and fix it.

Interviewer: Would you recommend GBF to another young person with a disability?

Lan: I would recommend it with warnings. Better than nothing. Not yet good enough to be proud of.

BN-04 - Hang, On the waitlist, Binh Duong

Interviewer: Hang, how long have you been waiting, and what has that been like?

Hang: Seven months. I check my phone every morning like a superstition. Nothing. My father asks weekly whether I am 'still waiting for that charity course'. He wants me to take any factory overtime. I tell him GBF means a real pathway. Some weeks I believe myself. Some weeks I do not.

Interviewer: Have other programmes approached you?

Hang: YouthWorks offered a six-week course, free, starting quickly. No internship at the end. I went to the briefing. It felt rushed - smile, certificate, goodbye. I stayed on the GBF list because I want a job with social insurance, not only a short class. But every month I wait, YouthWorks looks more reasonable. Waiting is also a decision cost.

Interviewer: What would make you finally switch?

Hang: If GBF cannot give me a start date within the next two months, I will take YouthWorks and keep looking for insurance later. I cannot be loyal to a queue forever. Loyalty does not pay rice.

Interviewer: What do you actually need from a programme?

Hang: Something that ends in a contract, or at least a serious employer interview. Transport help if the workplace is far. And honesty about timing. Do not tell me 'soon' for seven months. Say the number on the waitlist and where I sit. Treat me like an adult.

Interviewer: Any message for the people designing GBF's next three years?

Hang: If you scale without shortening the wait, you are scaling disappointment. I am not against growth. I am against growth that leaves people like me refreshing a blank inbox.

DN-01 - Ms. Huong, Programme Officer, VPBank Foundation

Interviewer: What does VPBank Foundation need to see to renew and expand support?

Huong: Three things, stated simply. First, a placement rate of at least 65 per cent at ninety days under a definition we can audit. Second, a credible path to 4,000 young people by 2028 - not a slogan, a resourced plan. Third, a monitoring framework we can trust, including the ugly numbers. We are a foundation attached to a bank. We understand risk. We do not understand surprise.

Interviewer: Does gig work count toward the 65 per cent?

Huong: If it is stable and at least fifteen hours a week, the agreement language allows it. But we would strongly prefer formal employment reported separately. Dual reporting protects everyone. A single blended rate that hides fragility will eventually damage the relationship.

Interviewer: What if GBF asked to slow geographic expansion and fix quality first?

Huong: We would listen. We could consider a smaller, quality-focused grant structure for a period. But the Board would need to bring us a credible theory of change - what will be fixed, by when, with which leading indicators - not simply 'give us time'. Other organisations are competing for this money. Patience without a plan is not a proposal.

Interviewer: What would worry you most in a board recommendation from this team?

Huong: Aggressive scale with no answer for Dong Nai. Or a recommendation that treats 65 per cent as a branding target rather than an operational truth. Bring us ambition and honesty in the same document. We can work with that. And please read the agreement carefully before you invent a cleverer measurement story than the one we already negotiated.

EP-01 - Mr. Khang, HR Manager, gold-tier employer partner

Interviewer: How do GBF interns perform in your operation?

Khang: Mixed, and I will not pretend otherwise. The best are excellent - we hired twelve last year into longer contracts. They show up, they learn the floor, they ask questions. The weakest lack basic punctuality and seem surprised that logistics is physical work. GBF prepares them well on soft skills and confidence. Factory discipline and stamina are thinner. That gap matters on a 5 a.m. shift.

Interviewer: Would you take more interns if GBF asked?

Khang: If they were better pre-screened, yes. We get too many who want an office job and discover on day two that the role is warehouse and routing. That wastes everyone's time. Also - and I will be frank - it is awkward that GBF Staffing Solutions then charges us a fee to hire the same young people permanently. It feels like we are paying twice: once in training goodwill, once in a placement fee. I still partner with GBF because the best graduates are worth it. But do not ask me to call that structure elegant.

Interviewer: Have you seen differences by hub - for example Dong Nai versus HCMC?

Khang: I do not track hubs the way GBF does. I track who arrives ready. When someone arrives exhausted from a long commute and already bitter about money, the internship fails before skill is tested. That is not only a training issue.

Interviewer: What should GBF stop doing, from an employer's seat?

Khang: Stop sending volume to look busy. Send fit. And visit the floor after week two, not only at signing. Partners notice when oversight is ceremonial.

EP-02 - Ms. Trang, Operations manager, logistics subcontractor (anonymous)

Interviewer: Thank you for speaking with us off the record. How does your firm actually use GBF interns?

Trang: Look, I will be straight with you, because the polite version helps nobody. We are short-staffed in peak season. The interns help with sorting and packing. We pay the legal minimum stipend, but the work is repetitive and the hours are long. There is no beautiful learning journey. GBF visited once at the start - handshake, photo, gone. We have not seen a caseworker since. I am not proud of how we use them. If GBF stopped sending people, we would manage with overtime and contractors. The interns are convenient, not sacred.

Interviewer: Do the young people complain?

Trang: Some do, quietly. Some quit. We replace them. That sentence should bother you. It bothers me when I say it out loud. Inside the business, it is normalised.

Interviewer: Would better monitoring from GBF change your behaviour?

Trang: Yes. If someone actually checked hours, duties, and whether we were teaching anything, we would clean up. Not because we became saints overnight - because we would not risk the partner channel. Right now there is no risk. No risk means no change.

Interviewer: Would you take more interns under current arrangements?

Trang: Only if someone checked that we were treating them properly. Otherwise you are asking me to participate in a fiction - that this is always 'opportunity'. Sometimes it is just cheap labour with a programme name. You should decide whether that is acceptable before you scale.

Interviewer: Anything else the Board should hear from your side of the market?

Trang: Gold-tier partners will give you nice quotes. Ask the subcontractors too. That is where the harm hides.

VR-01 - Chi Hoa, Volunteer mentor, three years

Interviewer: Is the mentoring model sustainable from where you sit?

Hoa: Barely. Volunteers burn out. I mentor four young people, which is too many if you are doing it properly - weekly calls, emergency messages, sitting with someone while they cry about a boss or a parent. We get a two-hour orientation and then we are on our own. When a case is light, it is rewarding. When it is heavy, I feel unqualified and still responsible. That combination empties people.

Interviewer: What kind of 'heavy' are we talking about?

Hoa: Domestic violence. Debt collectors. A young person who messaged me at midnight about not wanting to wake up. I am a mentor, not a clinician. I called the field officer and stayed on the phone until morning. We need professionals in the chain. Volunteers can walk beside someone. We cannot be the entire safety system.

Interviewer: Could volunteers replace paid field staff to save cost while scaling?

Hoa: No. Absolutely not. Anyone who suggests that has not taken those midnight calls. Volunteers support the work; we cannot be the work. If the Board tries to replace caseworkers with mentors to hit a headcount target, you will get a quieter spreadsheet and louder harm.

Interviewer: What would make mentoring healthier?

Hoa: Fewer young people per mentor. Better supervision. Clear escalation paths. And please stop listing inactive mentors as if their hours still count - I have seen names on lists of people who left months ago. It makes the capacity look stronger than it is.

Interviewer: Would you still encourage a friend to volunteer?

Hoa: Yes, with eyes open. It matters. It is also unpaid emotional labour next to a professional gap. Be honest in the recruitment poster.

BD-01 - Mr. T.N., Member of the GBF Board

Interviewer: Where do you stand on the strategic choice in front of the Board?

T.N.: We must accept the VPBank money and scale - including Long An. I have political and provincial support lined up. If we hesitate, we lose momentum and we lose donors. The region is watching whether GBF is serious about growth or only serious about workshops in District 1. The 'pause and fix' talk worries me. It sounds virtuous. It often becomes delay.

Interviewer: What do you say to staff who argue Dong Nai is not ready?

T.N.: Fix Dong Nai in parallel. Do not hold the whole organisation hostage to one hub's problems. Every expanding NGO has a weak site. That is not a reason to refuse a once-in-a-decade grant. Hire, train, tighten employer standards - yes. Hide from growth - no.

Interviewer: Some voices say Long An expansion is influenced by personal networks.

T.N.: People always say that when they dislike a geography. Long An is part of the economic zone story. Young people there need pathways too. If the pilot had issues, improve the model and go again. Retreating to HCMC comfort is not equity.

Interviewer: What would you need from this consulting team to support their recommendation?

T.N.: A plan that says yes to VPBank with eyes open - staffing numbers, timeline to 4,000, and how 65 per cent stays honest. If they come back with 'slow down and hope the foundation

waits', they will find a chilly Board room. Ambition is not the enemy of integrity. Fear is.

Interviewer: Any red line for you personally?

T.N.: Publicly refusing the grant without a better funded alternative. That would be organisational self-harm dressed as principle.